

Did you know?

AMAZING FACTS



Bristlecone pine tree

The oldest individual living plant (as opposed to a clump) is thought to be a bristlecone pine (*Pinus longaeva*). Named Methusaleh, it is currently 4,900 years old. It lives in the White Mountains of California, but its exact location is kept secret to protect it from harm.

The orchid family has more species than any other flowering plant, with 25,000–30,000 species recognized, mostly in tropical regions. Orchids are found in every continent except for Antarctica, inhabiting just about every type of environment, except for extreme deserts and salt water.

Arctic lupine



The oldest seed known to botany comes from the North American Arctic lupine plant and is thought to be about 10,000 years old.

The tendency of lupine seeds to be naturally preserved by the cold gave scientists the idea to place seeds in cold storage as stock for the future.

The fynbos, or evergreen bushland, of the Cape region in South Africa contains one of the world's most dense concentrations of plant species within a small area. The eastern and northern coasts around Cape Town are home to an amazing range of aloes, proteas, and ericas. There are an estimated 6,500 plant species in this tiny region. This is almost as many as in the whole of the continent of Europe.

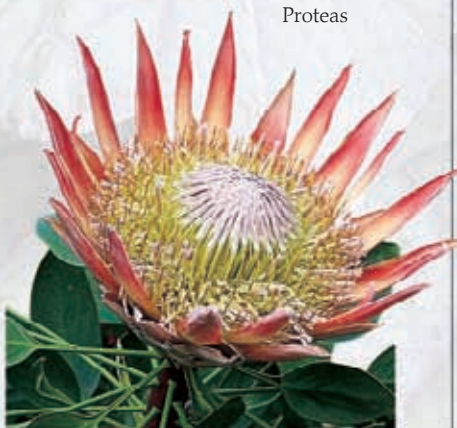
Sphagnum moss, which is found in bogs and contributes to the formation of peat, can soak up more than 25 times its own dry weight in moisture.

As plants get smaller we know less about them. Scientists estimate that they have identified 85–90 percent of flowering plants, but only about 5 percent of the world's microscopic organisms.

The largest fruit is the pumpkin, which can weigh up to 1,130 lb (513 kg). Its close rival is the squash, which has been known to grow to 893 lb (405 kg).

The main ingredient in chocolate is the bean of the cacao tree, which grows in the rain forests of South America.

Proteas



Fossils of the still-existing ginkgo tree (*Ginkgo biloba*) date back some 160 million years. It first appeared at the time of the dinosaurs, during the Jurassic period. Today, extract from the bark and root of the tree is considered to have medicinal benefits for humans. The seed kernel of the tree is a delicacy in China.

The raffia palm (*Raffia ruffia*) of Madagascar and Africa's tropical eastern coast has the world's largest leaves, measuring up to 65 ft (20 m) in length.

The banyan tree (*Ficus benghalensis*) has aerial roots that grow down from the tree's branches and eventually form new trunks. In this way, the banyan grows both upward and downward.

Japan greatly values the flower of the chrysanthemum and includes its emblem on the national flag. The country has dedicated a whole day to the flower, September 9, and the *feng shui* tradition teaches that the chrysanthemum brings laughter and happiness to a home.

Tulips were originally native to Turkey, Iran, Syria, and parts of Asia, before being brought to Europe by traveling merchants in the 16th century. The Dutch were the first European nation to cultivate tulips, doing so in 1593. By 1633, the Dutch upper classes were so gripped by tulip mania that individual bulbs were changing hands for vast amounts of money.

A plant called St. Mary's bean, from Central America, has the greatest known range for drifting seeds. Its seeds have been washed up in the Marshall Islands, in the Pacific Ocean, and also on the coast of Norway—places that are 15,000 miles (24,150 km) apart.

Orchid

